Week 8

JOURNEY

JOURNEY: ADVOCATES® · LEADER HANDOUT · UNIT 2 · LESSON 4

Naturalism

BIG IDEA

Naturalism, the dominant worldview of the West, says only what our five senses can detect is real and that science alone must supply life's meaning. But it cannot answer why we exist or account for justice, love and morality, and without God, as Ecclesiastes says, everything is meaningless.

Key points from the Leader Video

1. Naturalism says only what the five senses can detect makes up reality; students meet it every day, especially in science, math and technology classes.
2. It claims any meaning in life must come through science, but science only reaches the natural world; the goal is for students to see naturalism can't work.
3. Closely tied to atheism, it can't explain how the universe came to be or why; the "why" question can be asked again and again without an answer.
4. Justice, love and morality can't be touched or tasted, yet some morals hold for all cultures and all time, so they demand a deeper explanation.
5. Solomon opens Ecclesiastes with "meaningless, meaningless": without God putting meaning in life, all our labor and effort comes to nothing.
6. Rejecting God while caring for orphans, widows and clean water is inconsistent; that sense of justice points beyond nature to a Creator God.

FOR YOU

Before club: think it through yourself.

1. Where does an "only what I can see counts" mindset creep into how you think or live during the week?
2. Why do you care about justice and love, and how would you explain that to someone who doesn't believe in God?
3. How can you let the discussion flow freely while still gently challenging students' thinking?

ASK YOUR GROUP

In small group: questions to ask your students.

1. In your own words, what does naturalism say is real, and where does it say meaning comes from?
2. Where do you see naturalism show up in your classes or at school, beyond evolution?
3. If only the natural world exists, where do justice, love and right and wrong come from?
4. Why do people who don't believe in God still care about clean water or helping others? What might that point to?
5. What gives your work and effort meaning, and how would your answer change without God?

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WEEK 8 · LEADER VIDEO

The full transcript

The talk from this week's Leader Video, lightly edited for reading. Times point back to that moment in the video.

Which worldviews to cover

0:05 We've talked about what worldviews are, but what worldviews should we actually talk about? What worldviews are your students most exposed to? There are a lot of them. We're only going to touch on a couple of the most popular worldviews, and we're going to talk about some of the more dominant ones, as well as what a biblical worldview starts to look like. But the first one we're going to talk about is the idea of naturalism.

What naturalism teaches

0:35 You can probably tell right out of the gate that the idea of naturalism has the idea of nature in it. Think of your senses. Think of the five senses that you have — what you can taste, touch, smell, and feel. Naturalism teaches that only those things are what constitutes reality, and there we're back to that word again. What is reality? When we're talking about these other worldviews, they're doing the same thing that we're trying to do: trying to talk about what is reality and what is truth. How do we interpret these things in light of what naturalism actually is? Those who believe in naturalism are trying to take the five senses and interpret reality and dictate what is true based on those factors. That's essentially what they're doing.

1:25 And this really — if you think about your students, especially those in public schools — this is exactly what they're being exposed to every day of the week. It's this idea of naturalism, especially for those students who are in STEM research type classes: science, math, et cetera, technology, those kinds of things. Because the sciences are very much focused on the idea of what we can observe, what we can see, what we can touch, what we can taste, what we can feel. Those kinds of things.

1:53 But also, what they're trying to do is not only figure out reality and truth, but they're trying to figure out meaning. Naturally, life has meaning. And this is where it gets a little bit tricky. The naturalism point of view, the naturalism worldview, is trying to figure out, well, what does it mean to have meaning in life? That's sort of sticky, because naturalism actually can't do that. From the viewpoint of naturalism, you're being told that any meaning in life has to be found through science. So science is the only one that can determine what kind of meaning there is. But science can only take us through the natural world. It doesn't consider anything else. And we'll get to more of that in a second.

Why naturalism can't work

2:47 But what I want you to get is that this lesson is more than just understanding what naturalism is. It's being able to see that it can't work. And what we want our students to be able to determine is that they're not going to get away from it, because it's the dominant view of Western culture — but to be able to see things through it and interpret things in light of it, and

to understand that naturalism might be trying to do these things, and might be trying to explain meaning through science and the natural world, the natural order of things and all that, but at the end of the day it doesn't really work. Why?

3:25 Well, because naturalism is most closely associated with the idea of atheism, which means no God, it cannot explain two fundamental questions. It can't explain the universe in terms of how, and it can't explain things in terms of why. Now, science is trying to do this. Science is trying to figure out how the universe was created, and how things got here, and how it is that we're all here. But science can't do this. It can't determine why. Is it just random? If it's random, why is it random? We could keep asking that why question over and over and over again.

4:17 And to dig a little bit deeper, it also can't do things like determine justice, love, morality. How do we determine those things? How do we bring up the reality that there is justice in the world? How do we bring up the reality that two people love each other, and that we should have love for our fellow humans and humankind? Why is killing somebody else wrong, even if it might benefit me? Why is stealing wrong? Why do we understand some morals to be universal for all cultures, of all people, of all time? Where do we get these things from?

5:04 See, this is where naturalism falls short, because when we're talking about things like justice, love, and morality, these aren't tangible things that I can grab hold of. These are not part of what I can taste, touch, smell, and physically feel. I can't do that with justice, necessarily. I can't really do that with morality. These are things that are deeper than what is on the surface, and they require a deeper explanation. So again, it's important for us to understand not only what naturalism actually is, but it's also important for us to understand that naturalism doesn't actually work.

In your small groups

5:46 So in your small groups — especially in your small groups — make sure you take the time to allow students to discover and discuss how naturalism manifests itself in Western culture. What does that look like? Where do they see that in their schools and in their classes? It's not just evolutionary science and those kinds of things; it might be deeper than that. So get your students to have those discussions and get them to see beyond just the surface of what naturalism is, and have them start to analyze it in terms of reality and truth.

Ecclesiastes and meaninglessness

6:20 One thing that's great about this Bible study is that we dive into Ecclesiastes and the things that Solomon wrote. I think he had this spot on, and it brings so much more to the surface when we consider this book in light of naturalism. He writes in the very, very beginning, right out of the gate: "Meaningless, meaningless, says the teacher, utterly meaningless. Everything is meaningless. What does man gain from all his labor at which he toils under the sun? Generations come and generations go, but the earth remains forever." And what he's getting at through this whole book is the idea that without God putting meaning in life, life is meaningless — that all of our work and all of our efforts and everything that we stand for is meaningless.

7:11 So think about it. From a naturalistic perspective, without God, what is justice? Without God, what is love? Without God, what is morality? Why are we working, besides to make money? Why is there any nonprofit organization at all? Why do we care about clean water around the world? Why do we care about any of those things? Because from a naturalistic worldview, there is no meaning behind those things. There's no point to doing it, because we're all just going to die and be dust, and everything is going to go away, and we cease to exist.

7:49 But because we have the inclination to want to provide clean water, because we feel a sense of justice, because we understand certain morals are universal, because we love one another and we're called to love one another, we understand that there has got to be something greater beyond just the natural world. There has to be the supernatural world. There has to be a Creator God behind all of it.

The buffet of worldviews

8:18 So we see so clearly — and I want your students to see this as well — that when we talk about naturalism, it might sound so easy and so simple. When we talk about that big buffet of worldviews, it might sound like, "Oh yeah, this idea works really well." But when they go down that buffet and they decide that, yeah, I believe in naturalism and I don't believe in God, but I believe in taking care of orphans and widows and providing clean water to children around the world who don't have it — those two things are now inconsistent. Those two things no longer make sense together. It's a great thing that you want to provide that for those people, but why do you want to do that?

8:57 So this goes back to what we talked about last week, with the idea that it has to be consistent. So if you're going to desire to take care of your fellow man and take care of people who can't take care of themselves, if you have that sense of justice and you have that sense of morality — why? Again, it takes us back to here, and naturalism can't answer that. So naturally, what we would say is that your worldview then needs to adjust. So help your students navigate this. This is a little bit tricky, and it requires some good discussions. Again, we'll keep reminding you: always, always, always let the discussion flow. Let students be honest about what they think, but challenge them in their thinking.